AXAR PATEL, 32

Vice-captain/ all-rounder

Bapu, sehat ke liye tu toh hani-karak hai (Bapu, you are danger-ous for health). So goes a line from 'Hanikarak Bapu', a catchy song in the sports blockbuster *Dangal*. It's an apt descriptor for India's T20 vice captain Axar Patel, who goes by the petname Bapu. The moniker rightly suggests an affable person, but onfield adversaries know him only for his lethality—with bat, ball or in the field.

This T20 World Cup, the all-rounder with big shots, who adds depth to the lower middle order, averaged only 5 with the bat. He took 11 wickets at an econo-my rate of 8.2 with the ball. But stats seldom capture a player's impact fully. Washington Sundar replaced Axar for the match against the Netherlands and the first super-eight game against South Africa, because he was seen as a better batter. Sundar's underwhelming performance against South Africa allowed Axar to stage a comeback. This time, he clung on to his spot.

In the semifinal against England, his two brilliant catches that dismissed Harry Brook—which drew parallels to Kapil Dev's catch for the dismissal of Viv Richards in the 1983 ODI World Cup final—and Will Jacks ensured England never quite climbed the mountain of runs before them. In addition, he also dismissed Tom Banton. In the final, Axar's three wickets pegged New Zealand back repeatedly, allowing Jasprit Bumrah to run through their tail end.

Despite performing con-sistently since 2024, the fierce competition for a spot in the Indian T20 team means that Axar cannot take for granted a place in the starting XI. Yet, whenever he is left out, Team India loses some of the fluidity in their line-up—a wicket-taking bowl-er capable of choking opponents; a long handle who can hunker down too. If this Indian team excels at performing under pressure, Axar is an inherent part of it ■

—Siddharth Vishwanathan

AXAR PATEL
MATCHES: 7
WKTS: 11
BEST: 3/27
ECO: 8.2



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ISHAN KISHAN
MATCHES: 9
RUNS: 317
HS: 77
S/R: 193.29